

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

SATURDAY, DECEMBER 27, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Analysts divided on Nigeria claims

Muslim majority in area US hit see brunt of terrorism attacks

By Ruth Maclean, Saikou Jammeh and Ismail Auwal
The New York Times

After the U.S. military launched airstrikes on sites in northwestern Nigeria on Thursday, President Donald Trump said the targets were Islamic State group terrorists

“who have been targeting and viciously killing, primarily, innocent Christians.”

But analysts say that the situation on the ground is far more complicated.

Sokoto state, which was hit by more than 12 Tomahawk missiles Thursday night, is populated overwhelmingly by Muslims, who bear the brunt of terrorist attacks there, according to analysts and groups that monitor conflict. Bishop Matthew Hassan Kukah of Sokoto said recently that the area does “not have a problem with persecution” of Christians.

And analysts are divided over the exis-

tence of ties between insurgent groups in Sokoto and the Islamic State group.

Some analysts say that the violent attackers in Sokoto, who are colloquially known as the Lakurawa, have links to the Islamic State group’s Sahel Province branch, which is mostly farther north and west, in Mali, Niger and Burkina Faso.

But other analysts say evidence of those links is inconclusive, as the identity of the Lakurawa group remains murky. Its militants have operated in Sokoto and other Nigerian states for years, winning popularity by fighting local bandits at first and then

turning on the rural population.

“There’s a lot of fluidity and not a lot of ideological alliances,” Alkasim Abdulkadir, a spokesperson for Nigeria’s foreign minister, Yusuf Tuggar, said of the Lakurawa.

Even as Nigerian authorities have disputed Trump’s claims about a Christian “genocide,” they have chosen to respond to his threats by cooperating with his administration. Nigeria has taken the opportunity to use U.S. firepower against insurgents who have plagued rural communities in the coun-

Turn to Nigeria, Page 4



DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Warmer temperatures this weekend

Ice skaters glide past Cloud Gate in Chicago’s Millennium Park the day after Christmas as warmer temperatures reached the area Friday. The weekend forecast predicts higher-than-normal temperatures before returning to normal next week.



Daphne Labault puts merchandise on display in her Puerto Rican-inspired cafe and handicrafts store Plena Mercancia in Chicago’s Humboldt Park neighborhood on Tuesday. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Chicagoan from Puerto Rico must delay dream of return

Rising costs dashing hopes of many displaced by hurricane

By Laura Turbay
Chicago Tribune

When Daphne Labault left her home in San Juan, Puerto Rico, after Hurricane Maria blew her windows out, her dream was to go back someday.

“Returning had always been our north, our goal,” said Labault, 33, who came to Chicago with her partner about two months after the September 2017 hurricane and now lives in Edgewater.

In 2024 she launched Plena Mercan-

cia, a Puerto Rican coffee shop in Humboldt Park named for its *plena*, or plain, locally sourced sugar and artisanal goods. Labault wanted to create a space for people to chat over coffee, like they do in Puerto Rico.

“I’ve been able to create this little piece of Puerto Rico outside of Puerto Rico but always with the wish of wanting to go back,” she said. Her hope is to raise enough money to buy a house and move

Turn to Return, Page 2

A fallen e-commerce star, Groupon tries for comeback

Tucked away in downtown office building, company quietly executing turnaround

By Robert Channick
Chicago Tribune

Inside Groupon’s 2-year-old headquarters on the 25th floor of the Leo Burnett Building in downtown Chicago, a giant cat in a space-ship with flashing lights greets visitors in an otherwise staid office tower.

Here, the quirky e-commerce startup once dubbed the fastest-growing company ever, amid Super Bowl ads and ubiquitous media coverage, is quietly executing a turnaround after years of downsizing and red ink. Groupon is trying to become the next big thing once again. It happened once before.

“We’re at a point now in our journey where we have some victories, we have some things to look at, some proof points,” Groupon’s chief financial officer, Rana Kashyap, said during a recent tour of the

newly expanded headquarters. “And everyone loves a comeback story.”

In 2023, Groupon, whose daily deals platform made it the startup star of the post-millennium Chicago tech scene, was teetering on the brink of insolvency.

A groundbreaking unicorn that once spurned a \$6 billion takeover offer from Google on its way to a \$25 billion valuation, Groupon had fallen to a fraction of its previous worth amid dramatic downsizing and sharp revenue declines.

When Dusan Senkypl, a Czech investor and the company’s largest shareholder, took control of the struggling e-commerce site and announced a turnaround strategy, Groupon issued a “going concern” warning to investors in May 2023 that the company could be out of business within a year.

“It was not a great situation for the business,” said Kashyap, 43, a New York-based former hedge fund investor who joined Groupon in January 2023 under Senkypl’s

Turn to Groupon, Page 4

CHICAGO SPORTS

Bears battle for position

With two games left in the regular season, the Bears need a win or a Packers loss — or a tie by both — to lock down their first NFC North title since 2018. The longer shot would be securing the No. 1 seed, which earns a first-round bye and home-field advantage throughout the NFC playoffs.

